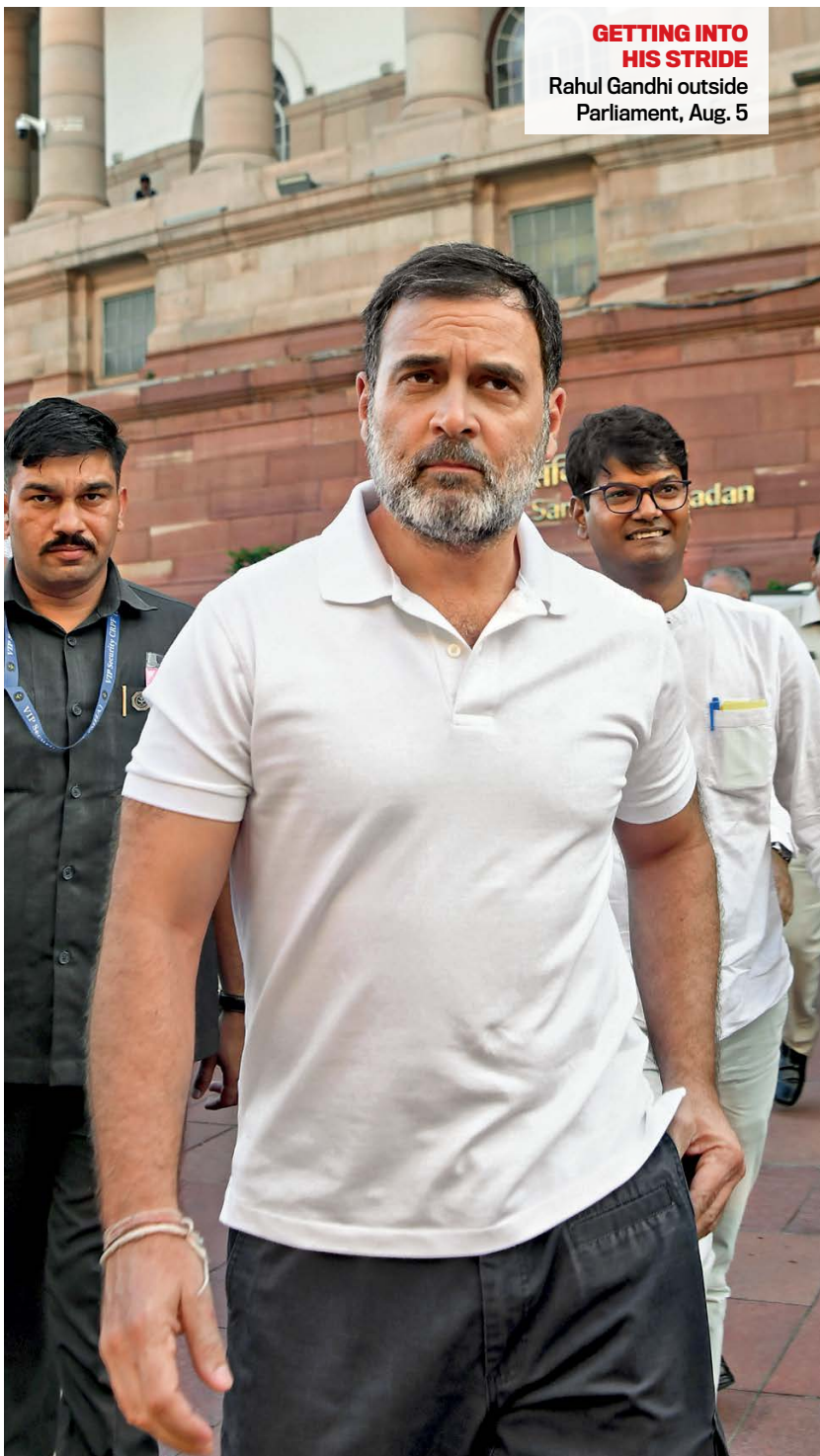
RAHUL RECAST

The Congress scion's performance as Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and outside it has won him new admirers, but the Opposition needs to do much more if it has to take the fight to the BJP

By KAUSHIK DEKA



GETTING INTO HIS STRIDE
Rahul Gandhi outside Parliament, Aug. 5

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IT was a monsoon-heavy July afternoon in Delhi, and the Lok Sabha was abuzz with anticipation. Members of Parliament, the seasoned and greenhorns alike, straightened in their seats in anticipation as Rahul Gandhi took the floor. His presence, once dismissed as inconsequential, now commanded the hall's full attention. In fact, his first speech in the 18th Lok Sabha drew interventions even from Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

If the first speech was about how religion teaches non-violence—and how the Modi government's 10-year-old reign has been promoting "hate politics"—in his second address, Rahul built his narrative around the Mahabharata, a tale as old as Indian civilisation itself. He spoke of Abhimanyu, the young warrior who was trapped and slain by a coalition of his enemies—men who bent the rules of war to ensure his defeat. The parallels he drew were debatable, but the newfound confidence in his tone was unmissable. Rahul likened Abhimanyu's plight to that of to-